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The fungibility of intersectionality: an Afropessimist reading

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ABSTRACT
What makes intersectionality an empty shell onto which scholars of all stripes can conveniently project their own concerns and feel completely legitimate to do so? What authorizes the easy removal of Black feminists from their theoretical innovation, intersectionality? Asking these polemical questions, the article engages a constellation of concepts (Black fungibility, natal alienation, slavery's afterlife) typically attached to Afropessimism to propose exploratory answers. Despite a lack of strong affinities between these two strands of Black theorizing, intersectionality and Afropessimism, the latter provides a useful interpretive lens to illuminate the former's post-Black feminist makeover in contemporary academe. Bringing evidence of the fungibility of Black women's bodies and knowledges within current academic dealings with intersectionality, this inquiry also invites all scholars engaging intersectionality to build a defensive front against violent academic extractivism that unfolds through the removal of Black women and Black feminism from intersectionality.

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The entry point is a remark made a quarter century ago by pioneering Black literary scholar, Barbara Christian. In her aptly titled essay, *Diminishing returns. Can Black feminism(s) survive the academy?*, Christian cautions, "[i]t would be a tremendous loss, a distinct irony, if some version of Black feminist inquiry exists in the academy to which Black women are not major contributors" (1994, 173). Writing the same year, another Black feminist literary theorist, Ann duCille, echoes Christian's insight, as she unravels academe's appetite for a kind of Black difference emptied of actual Black bodies, its eagerness to "have that 'signifying Black difference' without the difference of significant blackness" (1994, 600). duCille's remarks specifically target Black women's academic commodification: "Within the modern academy, racial and gender alterity has become a hot commodity that has claimed black women as its principal signifier" (591). With hindsight, one realizes how prescient these

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Black feminist scholars were in their grasp of stakes involved in institutionalizing Black feminist knowledge within the university. Their perceptive interventions paint "a powerful picture of a bleak and ironic future, one in which the university's fetishization of black feminism as intellectual inquiry does not render impossible, and indeed in some ways facilitates, its systemic violence against black women" (Hong 2008, 96).

Their prognosis holds also true for intersectionality, and most acutely so. Over the last two decades, intersectionality has become the hottest feminist commodity celebrated in many academic circles as the most significant theoretical contribution of feminism to date, while the institutional site it inaugurated is no longer informed by the kind of Black feminist aspirations and commitments "centering the lives of black women and girls while actively struggling against racism, sexism, heterosexism, classism, and other intersecting modalities of oppression" (Williamson 2017, 7). In our current moment, intersectionality's Black feminist roots are routinely paid lipservice or put on a pedestal in ways that turn Black feminists into relics (Cooper 2015), while it is also prematurely disposed of, declared a passé concept that outlived its analytical usefulness. This paradoxical engagement with intersectionality – how it is simultaneously hailed and failed (Bilge 2013), hypervalued and devalued (Nash 2019), has both inflationary and deflationary appeals (Carastathis 2016) – conjures up an image of conceptual bubble akin to financial bubble occasioned by recklessly speculative market behaviour.[1] Such contradictory engagements were also observed to a lesser extent in the field of gender/race/class studies – a predecessor of intersectionality as academic formation (Collins and Bilge 2016), which was simultaneous trivialized and sanctified (Bannerji 1995, 97).

The stakes in investing or divesting intersectionality can be thought through Bourdieu's broad argument in *Homo Academicus*. The university field, says Bourdieu, is similar to any other field,

> the locus of struggle to determine the conditions and the criteria of legitimate membership and legitimate hierarchy, that is, to determine which properties are pertinent, effective and liable to function as capital so as to generate the specific profits guaranteed by the field. (1988, 11)

This foregrounds the questions of what kinds of investments in intersectionality generate profit, who gets to decide what/who has value and what/who should be left behind so that intersectionality generates profits on the academic market. Several scholars concur in their assessments that intersectionality's academic success, however ambivalent, has come at the price of marginalizing Black women and knowledge within contemporary intersectionality studies, leading to what Nikol Alexander-Floyd (2012) deftly calls a "post-Black feminist" intersectionality.

The fetishization of Black feminism in general and intersectionality in particular in today's academe can be thought alongside other minoritized bodies

of knowledge that carry "the weight of a racial alibi" and are assigned within the institution a structural position of "fetishized marginality" (Lee 2000, 86, 91). These knowledge projects and their racialized workforce inhabit the paradox of being appointed by whiteness and signifying by our very presence in white spaces that the problem of institutional whiteness has been overcome (Ahmed 2012). This paradox has much to do with the neoliberal governance of diversity and how it unfolds within higher education institutions. Given that both Black feminism and intersectionality have been included in the western(ized) university mostly through the stewardship of academic feminism and the field of women's and gender studies (hereafter WGS), the engagement of WGS with these bodies of knowledge requires specific attention.[2] As Jennifer Nash pinpoints, intersectionality is invested by WGS as its "primary program-building tool and institutional goal", as "legitimizing strategy that programs and departments can mobilize to secure resources and to make tenure-track and tenured hires", even as "proof of the importance of the discipline itself", while it is also "rhetorically and symbolically collapsed into diversity", transformed into "an inclusion project that resonates with the mission of the so-called corporate university" (2019, 11–12, 16, 18). New institutional opportunities that this conjunction opens up for WGS unfold in a highly contradictory context in which minoritized knowledge projects simultaneously face commodification, branding and repurposing in line with institutional goals, and risk dismantlement because of budgetary cuts or political attacks as right-wing populist parties and movements gain power and influence in many countries around the globe. At the same time, these projects are supported across many universities by social justice-oriented student movements putting pressure on university administrations for more funding and the creation of new programmes in an era of heightened student activism for decolonizing knowledge and the university.

When it comes to WGS' engagement with intersectionality, it bears stressing that under WGS' purview, intersectionality is often managed in ways that make it stand synecdochically for entire Black feminism, which assumes that "the exclusive labor of Black feminist theory *is* intersectionality" (Nash 2019, 136). This assumption assigns to Black feminism a constricted short-term utility: Black feminists and intersectionality function as the "salvific figures" of white feminism and WGS (136), serving to fix their race problem. At the completion of this task, their service will no longer be needed. Academic feminism hence covertly promotes a post-Black feminist intersectionality, while using same intersectionality to signify the solving of its race problem and the dawn of its postracial times. Moreover, such synecdochic reductions work as a disciplining tool, subduing intersectionality in "a strange double gesture" where "intersectionality functions as a synecdoche for Black feminism and is then used to discipline the work of Black feminism" (Bliss 2016, 732).

One can reasonably ask in what ways intersectionality's institutional journey differs from those of other minoritized knowledge projects such as ethnic studies, WGS, postcolonial studies, Indigenous studies and theories from the Global South – areas of scholarly work that emerged from the emancipatory social movements of the '50s and '60s (in which anticolonial struggles and student activism stood prominently) and entered the western(ized) university through institutional compromise and devising which entail forms of containment and governance of dissent (Ferguson 2008).[3] To what extent can intersectionality's institutional life be illuminated by looking at institutionalization histories of these other minoritized knowledge formations? While such comparative approaches make certainly sense, for they provide insights into similarities and divergences between institutional trajectories, stakes and dilemmas these different knowledge fields grapple with, by also putting them in their broader social and historical context, I follow, in this article, a more controversial path, one that an anonymous reviewer called "a deeply provocative premise".

It is my contention that intersectionality as one strand of Black feminist knowledge is *uniquely* vulnerable to be emptied and disfigured in the present-day university. But *what makes Black feminist intersectionality infinitely elastic and exchangeable on the academic marketplace of ideas? How come that so many scholars approach intersectionality as an empty shell onto which they can project their own concerns and desires, and feel completely legitimate to do so?* I attempt to answer these questions (informed by a robust literature and my 20 years of engaging intersectionality in academic venues) by turning to the concepts of Black fungibility, slavery's afterlife (Hartman 1997, 2007) and natal alienation (Patterson 1982). Typically attached to another Black theorizing that came to be known as Afropessimism, these concepts allow new angles of inquiry to what authorizes the easy removal of Black feminists from their theoretical innovation, intersectionality. In so doing, I also put into productive tension and conversation two different strands of Black theorizing (intersectionality and Afropessimism) that are rarely taken up together.

Having said that, it bears stressing that this exploratory reading of intersectionality's post-Black feminist makeover through the lens of Black fungibility neither provides a systematic comparison between intersectionality and Afropessimism, nor calls for theoretical alliances that might misleadingly suggest strong affinities between them.[4] What it does instead is using the latter (selectively, not in all-or-nothing mode) to unpack the former – an inquiry of what authorizes intersectionality's decisively post-Black feminist turn through some Afropessimist insights. Stated differently, this article doesn't stand for or against Afropessimism; it rather engages with its idiom and conceptual tools to illuminate post-Black rearticulations of a specific Black feminist knowledge, intersectionality, in present-day academe. My arguments unfold in two

parts. First, I develop my theoretical argument about the fungibility of Black feminist academic production by deploying some tenets of Afropessimism as interpretive lens. Then, I ground my understanding of intersectionality in a specific Black feminist genealogy that precedes Crenshaw's foundational work and is situated in the context of formation of Black feminism as an autonomous social movement, and turn my gaze on contemporary academic engagements with intersectionality to provide evidence of intersectionality's post-Black feminist turn that I examine through the concepts of Black fungibility, natal alienation and slavery's afterlife.

The fungibility of Black feminist knowledge

Given the centrality of the concept of fungibility in my argument and its close ties to Afropessimism, it is worth starting by a succinct exposé of the latter's central tenets. First things first, Afropessimism under consideration here is the US-version of Afropessimism, which was developed several decades after its original elaboration in Africa (with a different meaning) and largely obscured this prior conceptualization.[5]

A foundational premise of (US-made) Afropessimism is the claim that humanity was "made legible through the irreconcilable distinction between humans and blackness" (Douglass, Terrefe, and Wilderson 2018, 1). The advent of "human" as category was achieved through the violent negation of humanity to the Black, classified as non-human. This founding relationality in which the Black non-human is the constitutive outside of the Human means that Blackness eludes and exceeds the humanist modes of thinking and world-making. This premise is buttressed by the Afropessimist conceptualization of Blackness as "a paradigmatic position, rather than an ensemble of cultural, social, and sexual orientations" (1), as a "structural position of noncommunicability in the face of all other positions" (Wilderson 2010, 58), which is coupled with a methodological refusal – that of any analogizing/comparison between the regimes of violence that discipline non-Black subalterns (dominated but human) and the one that evicts the Black from humanity. For Afropessimists, any analogizing between Black non-being and subjugated being (whether non-Black migrant, woman, queer, disabled) is misguided, as fungible object is incomparable to subordinated subject, and "the structure of the entire world's semantic field – regardless of cultural and national discrepancies – […] is sutured by anti-Black solidarity" (58). One can hardly miss the divergence between this Afropessimist precept of incommensurable ontological (anti)Blackness, which foregrounds one true antagonism, the one between Black non-human and non-Black human, while it views "other repressive relations like class and gender" as taking place "on the level of conflict – they can be resolved, hence they are not ontological" (Wilderson n.d.), and the intersectional relational schema which, without treating

differences as equivalent and interchangeable, conceives them within a matrix of domination where there is no superordinate antagonism. Thus, Afropessimist relational schema is hardly compatible with intersectional relational schema. While the former builds on the premise of only one true antagonism – that between humans and Blacks which is the core of ontological anti-Blackness – relegating the others to the realm of conflicts, because, it argues, they are not ontological, the latter eschews the idea of a single determination (be it race, class or gender) and focuses on theorizing their context-specific mutual constitution and articulations.

From an Afropessimist perspective, Blackness doesn't belong to the domain of subjectivity, identity, agency and epistemology, but to that of ontology, accumulation and fungibility, as determined by slavery and its afterlife (Hartman 1997). What ensue are structural incommensurability and incommunicability of Blackness vis-à-vis all other subaltern positions, "predicated on modalities of accumulation and fungibility, not [Marxian] exploitation and alienation" (Wilderson 2010, 58) – for slave is an object, not an exploited labourer-subject (Patterson 1982). They produce the "the absolute non-individuality and interchangeability" (Warren 2017, 397) of Blackness. Here, the concept of fungibility is of paramount importance, as the predicate upon which the enslaved Black is evicted from humanity and turned into ontologically (ac)cumulable and exchangeable commodity. Hartman (1997) argues:

> the fungibility of the commodity makes the captive body an abstract and *empty vessel vulnerable to the projection of others' feelings, ideas, desires, and values*; and as property, the dispossessed body of the enslaved is the *surrogate* for the master's body since it guarantees his disembodied universality and acts as the sign of his power. (21, my emphasis)

Slavery is determinant in the Afropessimist conceptualization of Blackness and its incommensurability with other social positions of oppression. For Afropessimists, "the black is positioned, a priori, as slave" (Douglass, Terrefe, and Wilderson 2018, 1). One may reasonably inquire, but what about post-emancipation? Afropessimists answer this via the concept "afterlife of slavery" (Hartman 2007) to argue "how the relationship between the slave and their status as fungible property did not substantively change after emancipation" (King 2013, 24). Hartman writes:

> Slavery had established a measure of man and a ranking of life and worth that has yet to be undone. If slavery persists as an issue in the political life of black America, it is not because of an antiquarian obsession with bygone days or the burden of a too-long memory, but because black lives are still imperiled and devalued by a racial calculus and a political arithmetic that were entrenched centuries ago. This is the afterlife of slavery – skewed life chances, limited access to health and education, premature death, incarceration, and impoverishment. I, too, am the afterlife of slavery. (2007, 6)

For Hartman, emancipation is "both a breach with slavery and a point of transition to what looks more like the reorganization of the plantation system than self-possession, citizenship, or liberty of the 'freed'" (1997, 12). Accordingly, the plantation supersedes its historical site, so does the fungible object status of the 'freed' Black. The lingering effects of slavery have an important bearing on my argument about Black feminist intersectionality's fungibility in present-day academe. If Hartman theorizes Black non-humanity as being predicated on fungibility, i.e. ontological status of infinitely cumulable and exchangeable commodity, from the structural position of the enslaved, her conception of slavery's *afterlife* authorizes the deployments of fungibility after and beyond slavery. Such a post-emancipation use of fungibility is obvious in Wilderson's work, when he argues:

> As an accumulated and fungible object, rather than an exploited and alienated subject, Black is openly vulnerable to the whims of the world *and so is his or her cultural 'production.'* What does it mean – what are the stakes – when the world can whimsically transpose one's cultural gestures, the stuff of symbolic intervention, onto another worldly good, a commodity of style? (2010, 56, my emphasis).

In so doing, Wilderson not only deploys fungibility beyond the historical site of slavery, but also expands it from Black bodies to their artistic and intellectual productions, which are up for grabs, to be done whatever anyone sees suitable. He writes:

> The object status of Blackness means that it can be placed and displaced with *limitless* frequency and across untold territories, by whoever so chooses. Most important, there is nothing real Black people can do to either check or direct this process. Both jazz and hip-hop have become known in the same way that Black bodies are known: *as forces "liberated" from time and space, belonging nowhere and to no one, simply there for the taking*. Anyone can say "[n-word]" because anyone can be a "[n-word]." (2010, 235, my emphasis)

Black fungibility under globalized hip-hop brings compelling insights to think through Black women's fungibility under globalized intersectionality, which becomes intersectionality's fungibility under globalized knowledge economy. In both cases (globalized hip-hop and intersectionality), Black bodies and intellectual/cultural production are in a state of infinite change and exchange. They are "open spaces of shifting 'signification and representation' which humans use to make meaning of their lives" (King 2016, 1023; drawing on Spillers 1987, 75). The enslaved body's ontological status predicated on fungibility and accumulation hence expands on Black experience and knowledge, turning them into "an open sign that can be arranged and rearranged for infinite kinds of use" (1025).

Grounding this article's theoretical argument about intersectionality's fungibility *qua* a specific Black feminist knowledge project on the work of Wilderson, which lacks a robust engagement with Black feminism or the

question of "what it means to inhabit the world of Black gender" (Douglass 2018, 111) wouldn't do justice to Black feminists' work engaging Afropessimism and attempting to navigate and address generative tensions – unfolding most often around gender – between the two projects. While thinkers most readily identified with Afropessimism such as Frank Wilderson and Jared Sexton are not known for their vigorous involvement with the depth and breadth of Black feminist work or the issue of Black female gender, several Black feminist scholars take on simultaneously Afropessimism and Black feminism and engage their complex, sometimes tense, relations.[6] In so doing, they advance our thinking about the Black female fungibility in slavery's afterlife, which is of particular salience for addressing intersectionality's fungibility as a Black feminist knowledge. The work of Erica Edwards (2015) opens up an important path here by tackling the commoditization of Black female sexuality through Black women's fungibility across various racialized regimes, from slavery to late capitalism. Building on Hartman and Edwards, another Black feminist, Shoniqua Roach uses the term "the fungibility of black femininity" to mean "black women's material and discursive elasticity" (2019, 127) in contemporary culture and politics, and argues:

> I join Edwards in contending that we cannot understand what is liberatory or antiliberatory about any given performance of black female sexuality without situating such performances in relation to the fact of black female fungibility and the deployment of black female sex and sexuality under particular social, political, and economic regimes (141).

Besides Black feminist scholars explicitly engaging with the idiom of Afropessimism, one can also turn to numerous writings by Black women academics about their lives in white institutions. In their autoethnographies, these academics illuminate how they face being turned into imprintable and disposable human tools (Patterson 1982) and are considered open spaces available to the whims of the (academic) world and the projection of others' feelings, ideas and projects (Hartman 1997). A case in point is the following account by race and sexuality studies scholar, Amber Musser:

> Identity politics within the institution and within sexuality studies conspire to produce me, a queer Black woman, as a specimen – that is to say, a commodity, static and rare. […] this feeling comes from two sources that are often assumed to speak opposing languages – one of liberation and the other of the corporation. […] This type of specimen is the stagnant. This is the version of the specimen that happens when a part stands in for a whole and a creature is caught and pinned up for display in perpetuity. (2015, 1–2, 9)

Musser's description of her institutional position as a *specimen* resonates with synecdochic reductions already discussed that form part of Black women's commodity-like status in the afterlife of slavery in white institutions. Interestingly, Musser identifies women's studies' insistence on intersectionality and

the university's investment in neoliberal diversity as the major sites of her institutional commodification.

Angela Mae Kupenda's testimonial brings additional insights. A law professor "who is black, female, southern, and from an economically disadvantaged background" (2012, 20), Kupenda recounts how in her early academic career, she was scolded by a white male administrator during her annual pre-tenure evaluation. There was no problem with her teaching, scholarship or service. The problem was that she didn't tell him and her colleagues enough about her personal life.

> He said I was beginning to be much too private, just like the other woman of color on the faculty [… and …] yelled, "You must trust us more if you want to succeed here; there are no spooks behind the door!". (20)

It is worth quoting her account at lengths, as it illuminates how her felt life in the academy is structured with slavery's afterlife, its haunting legacy.

> As a black female academic with more than twenty years of experience in academia, to tell the truth, ghosts *have* haunted me: the ghosts of Jim Crow; the goblin of slavery-like, white, presumed superiority; and ghouls of sexism, racism, and classism just will not leave me alone! Beneath the surface of seemingly innocent encounters with supposedly well-meaning white administrators or colleagues or students, these ghosts linger and haunt me with words and acts that torture my very soul and keep me from being able to experience academia the way a white male with similar credentials can. (21, Kindle)

> The white male administrator knowingly or unknowingly seemed to say blacks must be entertaining to have a place with other faculty; they must share private details to appeal to the voyeuristic interest that some whites feel about blacks […]. [T]his evaluation encounter was a visit from the enduring ghost of the slavery and postslavery treatment of black women and that academia is not immune from this ghost haunting its ivory towers. During slavery black women were not allowed any privacy, not even for their bodies, which were inspected, prodded, used for experiments, and vulgarly displayed for the economic profit of whites. Their innermost parts were available at the whim of the white master for his own personal exploration. (20–21)

African American studies scholar, LaMonda Horton-Stallings' comments provide yet another eloquent example:

> I am a black woman. I am a *living text*, but everyone around me has returned to early twentieth-century moves of attempting to write me, draw me, sing me, translate me, legislate and discuss me in dead languages. Black women are living texts that possess a wealth of wisdom of knowledge. *We are the discourse that others use to define their hopes and dreams, measure their living, and direct their strategies of resistance* […] (2012, 132, my emphasis).

What Horton-Stallings poignantly exposes in 2012 deeply resonates with Ann duCille's discernment two decades earlier: "Today there is so much interest in

black women that I have begun to think of myself as a kind of *sacred text*" (1994, 591, my emphasis) and goes on to reveal her distrust, shared by many Black women academics, of this new infatuation with Black female difference: "I am hardly alone in suspecting that interest in black women may have as much to do with the pluralism and even the primitivism of this particular postmodern moment as with the genuine quality of black women's accomplishments and the breadth of their contribution to American civilization" (591).

Here, it bears stressing that long before Afropessimism has become a coveted theory and fungibility a well-known concept, duCille captured with penetrating acuity "the production of black women as infinitely deconstructable "othered" matter" (591), and the turning of Black feminist knowledge into an empty signifier, available for picking up by anybody desiring so. duCille writes:

> Much of the newfound interest in African American women that seems to honor the field of black feminist studies actually demeans it by treating it not like a discipline with a history and a body of rigorous scholarship and distinguished scholars underpinning it, but like *an anybody-can-play pick-up game performed on a wide-open, untrammeled field*. Often the object of the game seems to be to reinvent the intellectual wheel: to boldly go where in fact others have gone before, to flood the field with supposedly new "new scholarship" that evinces little or no sense of the discipline's genealogy. (603, my emphasis)

In this regard, King's proposal about "proto-Afropessimism" (see note 7) makes perfect sense and allows an alternative genealogy for Hartmanian fungibility – one that starts with Black feminist literary theorists such as duCille and Christian with whom this article began. Both scholars took issue with the perils of institutionality for Black feminist knowledge in terms akin to fungibility. Linking their precursory work to contemporary scholarship on Black fungibility, particularly Black female fungibility (e.g. Edwards 2015; Roach 2019), also enables another kind of engagement with Black feminist work – one that does not "race for theory" (Christian 1987) and refuse cherry-picking only those viewed as cutting-edge in our present moment. Notably, such proclivities are manifest not only in academic feminism's dealings with Black feminist scholarship but also in Black studies. As Brittney Cooper notes, treating Black feminism as a "foundational *steppingstone* for other more exciting sites of inquiry" that is common in WGS can also be found in Black studies (2015, 12, my emphasis). Likewise, in her study of WGS' engagement with intersectionality, Nash points out how in our intellectual moment, "both women's studies and black studies, animated by distinct political desires and critical aspirations, have made intersectionality passé even as they deploy black feminist theory as a necessary investment" (2019, 22). For Nash, Black studies' "current orientation toward afropessimism engages black feminist theory largely through the work of Hortense Spillers,

Saidiya Hartman, Christina Sharpe, and Sylvia Wynter, often at the expense of a robust engagement with other black feminist debates, dialogue, and disagreement" (20). Reconsidering the scholarly work of duCille and Christian who are rarely included in Afropessimist debates about Black women opens up theoretical and political possibilities beyond the pitting of Black feminists against each other (Cooper 2015).

Having outlined the theoretical grounding of my argument on the fungibility of Black feminist knowledge through Afropessimist insights, I bring evidence in what follows of how intersectionality is made fungible with an infinite potential of exchange on the neoliberal academic marketplace of ideas.

An emptied intersectionality up for grabs

Black feminism meets with a curious fate in the academy: "Black feminism and Black feminist concepts are institutionalized to the degree that they can be separated from Black women, and they are critiqued to the degree that they cannot" (Bliss 2016, 731). This is particularly true for intersectionality. Its "intimacy with black women […] is imagined to devalue the analytic, and […] transcending black women […] is imagined to rescue intersectionality from obsolescence and to transform the field of women's studies" (Nash 2014, 61). Intersectionality is given all sorts of meanings, burdened with all sorts of tasks, such as signifying "mainstream feminism's arrival at a postracial moment" (Carastathis 2016), only to be chastised for failing to keep its alleged promises, while it is also construed as feminism's most viable future provided it become an *ever-expanding lens* that can and must attend to "*all* subjects' experiences", which implicitly entails "shed [ding] Black women" (Nash 2014, 46).

Kimberlé Crenshaw herself is acutely aware of intersectionality's curious fate within academe and public debates writ large. A *Chronicle of Higher Education* article on intersectionality describes Crenshaw as preferring "to steer clear of the rancor surrounding the word she coined" and quotes her calling the soaring attention given to intersectionality "stunning" and how the term "*gets attached to anything and everything* that critics don't like" (Bartlett 2017, 2–3, my emphasis). Actually, intersectionality gets attached to whatever its critics don't like and whatever its advocates want it to achieve, such as resolving feminism's race problem, generating a universal theory of identity or social stratification. I read such odd usages not as emanating from being an intrinsic quality of intersectionality but from the structural and ontological (anti)Blackness embedded in modernity's construction of the "human" (Wynter 1995). Stated differently, I treat it as a structure of signifying practices which can be illuminated by an Afropessimist orientation centreing on the fungibility of Blackness and the afterlife of its commodity-like status under slavery (Spillers 1987; Hartman 1997, 2007).

Before empirically grounding my postulate of Black feminist intersectionality's fungibility in present-day academe, I must situate my understanding of intersectionality in a specific Black feminist genealogy so as to flesh out my (contentious) claim that intersectionality is and should be considered as a Black feminist intellectual production.[7] Stating this doesn't mean that Black feminists developed intersectionality in isolation. In the late 1960s and 1970s, Black women in the US were part of heterogeneous alliances with Chicanas and Latinas, Asian-American and Indigenous women, and "their movements were in conversation/tension with the civil rights, Black Power, Chicano liberation, Red Power, and Asian-American movements" (Collins and Bilge 2016, 65) with important transnational ties to Black liberation movements in Africa and throughout the African diaspora and to anti-colonial struggles writ large. "Though their experiences and the social movements they engendered took different forms, these groups were also at the forefront of raising claims about the interconnectedness of race, class, gender, and sexuality in their everyday life experiences" (71).

By situating the elaboration of intersectionality's core ideas within the decades of revolutionary social movements of the 1960s and 1970s, I depart from intersectionality's prevailing histories that start with Crenshaw's field-defining interventions. In so doing, I don't minimize her immense contribution but consider a genealogy that deploys Floyd-Alexander's useful distinction between intersectionality as an *idea* and intersectionality as an *ideograph*. As an idea, intersectionality relates to the specific formulation developed by Crenshaw (1989) – which the literature often rehearses as "coining" the term. As an "ideograph", intersectionality encompasses a broader intellectual and political project of researching and confronting the multiple oppressions faced by Black and other racialized women. In Floyd-Alexander's words:

> As an ideograph, intersectionality serves as a catch-all word that stands in for the broad body of scholarship that has sought to examine and redress the oppressive forces that have constrained the lives of black women in particular and women of color more generally. As an idea or an analytically distinct concept, intersectionality is a moniker, identified with Crenshaw (1989), meant to describe the "intersecting" or co-determinative forces of racism, sexism, and classism in the lives of black women. (2012, 4)

This distinction enables the connecting of different genealogies of intersectionality without pitting them against one another, provided that they all centre racialized women as the locus of intersectionality's elaboration. Thus, whether one opts for a shorter genealogy starting with Crenshaw or a longer one that goes back to the nineteenth century figures of Black feminist thought such as Sojourner Truth, Anna Julia Cooper, Ida B. Wells, etc., or an intermediate one taking the social movements of the 1960s and 1970s with

Combahee River Collective as a water-shed moment (orientation I favour), one fact remains: intersectionality as thought and practice is the fruit of the labour of racialized women. In its idea form, as Floyd-Alexander understands, the authorship is more restrictive – Black women; in its ideograph form, it is broader, embracing "women of color more generally". Clearly, whether idea or ideograph, a racialized habitus is not an optional but a constitutive component of intersectionality. So how come that the most common contemporary understanding of intersectionality is "gender+", taking gender as the mandatory starting point and looking at its selected intersections with class, race, ethnicity, ability, age, and so on?[8]

I addressed elsewhere how intersectionality is converted into "gender+" through four main conduct patterns widespread in WGS and beyond: the first asserts that "intersectionality is the brainchild of feminism"; the second repurposes intersectionality to "nobler", i.e. "more universal" goals which entail moving it away from Black women; the third instructs that "intersectionality's genealogy must be broadened"; and the fourth normalizes postracial intersectionality under the guise of "travelling theory" (Bilge 2013, 413–20). Working together, they not only decentre race and marginalize racialized knowledge producers, particularly Black women, in contemporary research, teaching and advocacy on intersectionality – since feminism is deemed intersectional, it no longer has a race problem – but also bring into the fold of intersectionality's architects a list of feminists (all white) as its unacknowledged builders. Revisiting these disciplinary, genealogic and geographical moves through the lens of fungibility opens up new perspectives, linking them to the underlying pervasive treatment of Black (feminist) intellectual and cultural production as belonging nowhere and no one, being simply there for foraging and disfiguring. It also helps us to address the vexing question of how non-Black women of colour (WoC), not only white women, can inadvertently uphold structural anti-Blackness in our intersectional work.

A conception of intersectionality *just-being-there-up-for-grabs* informs an oft-heard narrative, in particular within European academic feminist circles, about intersectionality's advent. I called this "it was in the air" argument, as the narrative holds that intersectionality cannot be attributed to (US) Black feminists, since *it was in the air*. This assertion rests on the tacit notion that if intersectionality emerged from many (feminist) sites where "it was all in the air", then Black feminism is just a site among many others where intersectionality materialized – a claim bringing all to "the *internal* effervescence of feminism" and evading the historical fact that intersectionality was conceived *in tension*, not in teamwork, with (white) feminism (Bilge 2013, 744). Consider the following case in point.

In a high-profile European conference[9] on intersectionality where Crenshaw was a special guest, speakers were given a list of framing questions which highlight organizers' empty-shell approach to intersectionality,

turning it into a fungible commodity. Crenshaw mentions these questions in her original contribution to the coedited follow-up volume. In there, she discusses how these questions were central to the conference's discursive politics. They read as follows: "Can such an all-round, catch-it-all-concept possibly be more than a 'buzzword'? Can it be regarded as approximating an overarching theory of oppression and marginalisation at all? What are its geographical, topical and methodological limits?" (qtd in Crenshaw 2011, 222). One cannot help but notice how oddly these framing questions are framed. Phrasings like "can it possibly be more than", "approximating" and "at all", over-communicate; i.e. they communicate something exceeding, giving the impression that they are rhetorical questions for which organizers have already their answers. They seem to point to a tacit consensus. Significantly, describing intersectionality as "an all-round, catch-it-all concept" suggests an empty vessel conception of intersectionality in which anything and everything can be put. Once made fungible commodity, intersectionality is then devalued for its limitless exchangeability in the economy of significations, reduced to a "buzzword" (Davis 2008), as the first framing "question" puts it: *Can such an all-round, catch-it-all-concept possibly be more than a 'buzzword'?* This making of intersectionality vacant is not lost on Crenshaw, as she takes issue, in her "Postscript" piece, with approaches to intersectionality that attribute it an "empty-suit character" enabling analysts to create whatever theory they want to create (2011, 231–2). It is hard to miss the proximity between Crenshaw's critique of "empty-suit" treatment of intersectionality with the idea of Black fungibility and the related lexicon of "empty vessel/shell", "open sign", and so on.

Tinges of fungibility also run through, albeit in filigree, Barbara Tomlinson's sharp critique of some white feminists' dealings with intersectionality. Tomlinson neither uses fungibility nor its kin terms, but her analysis of how attempts to universalize intersectionality treat Black intersectional feminists as a synecdoche, "as if one stands for all", and interchangeable, "as if any can be substituted for another" (2018, 174), resonates with infinite exchangeability that underpins fungibility. Moreover, the loaded metaphor of *ventriloquism* she uses to tackle how some appropriations or critiques of intersectionality "make puppets of those who proposed intersectionality, making them appear to speak in 'deficient' ways and therefore justify the condemnation or appropriation of intersectionality" (209) is deeply evocative of infamous minstrelsy. For Tomlinson, white feminists' "ventriloquizing of straw women of color" (88) is not only poor scholarship but "a remarkable gesture of racial dominance" (209).

When intersectionality is annexed by academic feminism as the latter's own big idea, an evidence of feminism's internal vitality, it is rarely engaged in its own terms – terms put by Black feminists centreing Black women, their lifeworlds and freedom dreams. Instead it is treated like a blank

canvas, a fuel for other desires and agendas, unrecognizably redefined and repurposed. Thus, intersectionality can be reformulated as having "provided a name for a multiplicity of ongoing feminist debates" (Lykke 2010, 78), a tool for "the acknowledgement of differences among women" (Davis 2008, 70), "a productive rhizomatic deterritorialization" and "a discursive site where different feminist positions are in critical dialogue or productive conflict with each other" (Lykke 2011, 208). Burdened with all sorts of meanings and tasks, intersectionality is most often viewed as an antidote to mainstream feminism's various exclusions in general or its racism in particular, put thereby in the service work – that of serving (white) feminism. It is the white woman's Black nanny or help, a springboard for the former's self-discovery and personal growth. In today's academe, this "marshaling of black women's position, creativity, and labour can inaugurate any new field of operation and can extend any new terrain of possibility at the same time that it grandly ushers these same bodies into long-term harm" (Malaklou and Willoughby-Herard 2018, 15), and needs to read against what Walcott calls the university's "pathological hatred of Black women" (2018, 96). Such a long-term harm can be literally lethal as evidenced by the long list of Black feminist academics who met with premature death compiled in Hong's (2008) poignant article.

When it comes to attempts to universalize intersectionality, their underlying assumption is that Black women's knowledge is too particular to represent universality. For Prins, intersectionality centred on Black women's lives cannot produce a "general" model of identity, for they constitute a group "positioned on the fringes of society, for whom mechanisms of social power have […] become reified. [I]t is highly questionable to base one's general framework of identity upon such 'extreme' cases in which power works in a near totalitarian way". (2006, 282). She then goes on to argue for abandoning Black women's "cases" with "predictable plots of one party dominating the other" and theorizing from "more 'ordinary' cases" in which "differences in power cannot be simply added up to a singular picture"; for such a move would enable "subtler accounts" and "the narration of multilayered stories" (282). Such examples claiming that a more generalizable and universal intersectionality requires leaving behind Black women abound, showing how right is Crenshaw when she affirms: "[t]here is a sense that efforts to repackage intersectionality for universal consumption require a re-marginalising of Black women" (2011, 224).

Here, it is worth turning to a key Afropessimist premise to dig deeper. For Afropessimists, universal is the attribute of the Human, a modern category constructed through Black people's eviction from humanness, enabling thereby their turning into legal merchandise, "legitimately enslavable" (Wynter 1995, 35) fungible human commodities, which forms the bedrock of structural and ontological antiblackness that persists today as slavery's

afterlife. The ubiquitous tacit belief that universalizing intersectionality requires its separation from Black women gains greater clarity when read from this perspective. In the same way the fungibility of the enslaved is the necessary relationality for the construction of universal human subject, the fungibility of Black intersectionality is the necessary condition for disembodied universal intersectionality. Crenshaw alludes to this dynamic she qualifies "a particularly vexed contradiction", when she argues: "although intersectionality was coined to counter the disembodiment of Black women from law, the challenge today is to resist the disembodiment of Black women from intersectionality itself" (2014).

Accordingly, I contend that the widespread disquiet generated by centreing Black women – whether in class-action lawsuits examined by Crenshaw (1989) through which she first conceptualized intersectionality as an idea, or in contemporary debates on intersectionality – cannot be fully grasped if we stay debating within the terms laid by those who argue why intersectionality should move beyond Black women and produce counterarguments, for these terms are part and parcel of epistemic violence, the devaluing of Black women's lives and labour in contemporary academe and society writ large. The analytical lens of fungibility (Hartman 1997) is better suited to reveal how intersectionality, divorced from Black female bodies, becomes an abstract and empty vessel that can host disembodied universality and guarantee its power. Consider for instance how a specific rendition of intersectionality in which "the particularity of black women's identity position functions as the *formative ground* for a critical practice aimed at *infinite inclusion*" (Wiegman 2012, 241, my emphasis) feeds into the idea of unlimited exchangeability (fungibility) of Black women's structural position from which intersectionality emerged. Thus, the lens of fungibility enables us to envisage today's extractivism from and appropriations of Black women's intellectual labour as an instantiation of the "afterlife of slavery" (Hartman 2007) – how slavery produced fungible human commodities and has an enduring presence in the form of anti-Black racial violence, including epistemic violence discussed here, how Black containment in the afterlife of slavery also applies to the containment of Black knowledge in white institutions. An Afropessimist lens reveals that fungibility exceeds its historical site of slavery.

Claiming the necessity to divorce intersectionality from Black feminism and Black women's social positions and identities, which is patent both in intersectionality's genealogical makeover and in efforts to universalize it, can be unpacked through another concept that influenced Afropessimists: natal alienation. In *Slavery and Social Death*,[10] Orlando Patterson proposes natal alienation alongside gratuitous violence and general dishonour to theorize the condition of the enslaved as one of the socially dead – "a social nonperson" (1982, 5), an object, not a labourer. While gratuitous violence is exercised in the social domain of power characterizing the relation of slavery, and

general dishonour in the sociopsychological domain, natal alienation is a constituent of the cultural domain, one that has to do with authority and "the control of symbolic instruments", which constitute "the cultural counterpart to the physical instruments [like a whip] used to control the slave's body" (5, 8). For Patterson, the slaves are turned into socially dead (non)beings through their alienation from "all 'rights' or claims of birth", making them "to cease to belong in [their] own right to any legitimate social order" (5). It is this "alienation of the slave from all formal, legally enforceable ties of 'blood', and from any attachment to groups or localities other than those chosen for him by the master, that gave the relation of slavery its peculiar value to the master" (7). This refusal to formally "recognize the social relations of the slave[s] had profound emotional and social implications" (6), rendering their informal social relations (unions, families and communities) illegitimate and nonbinding. Coercively cut from their natal ties in both ascendant and descendent generations, slaves "differed from other human beings in that they were not allowed freely to integrate the experience of their ancestors into their lives, to inform their understanding of social reality with the inherited meanings of their natural forebears, or to anchor the living present in any conscious community of memory" (5) and to pass on these worlds of meaning to future generations. The slave is hence "truly a genealogical isolate" (5), formally denied a genealogical and historical memory.

Therefore, it stands to reason that the removal of intersectionality from Black feminist community symbolically reenacts the violence of severing generational ties and forced uprooting characterizing natal alienation. This is not to say intersectionality should stay immobile, but it should move *with* Black feminists. Voiced time and again, Black feminists' concerns over intersectionality's removal from Black feminist community cannot be addressed solely as signifiers of (negatively connoted) ownership, territoriality and proprietary relationships (e.g. Nash 2019). I sit uneasily with reading Black feminist labour against divorcing intersectionality from Black feminism as problematical "proprietary attachments to intersectionality" (Nash 2019, 3), containing Black feminism in a negative emotion of defensiveness, which is, Nash argues, "a form of obstructed agency, something that hinders black feminism's theoretical and political imagination rather than unleashing it" (137). Although I am receptive to Nash's careful argument about the costs of constantly defending intersectionality for Black feminists, I believe their critique warrant alternative interpretations.[11] One such alternative can be developed, I argue, by reconsidering Black feminist refusal of post-Black feminist intersectionality through the actual legacy of natal alienation and deracination (Patterson 1982). Under this light, what is seen as (negative) defensiveness and property relations can be understood as an affirmation of the right to one's genealogy and worlds of meaning, and a resistance against the denial of one's capacity for filiation. For Patterson, slave's forced natal alienation, i.e.

"the loss of ties of birth in both ascending and descending generations", also meant "a loss of native status, […] deracination" and transformed the slave into "the ultimate human tool, as *imprintable* and as *disposable* as the master wished" (1982, 7, my emphasis) – what Hartman (1997) would later call a fungible object. Accordingly, natal alienation forms part of the conditions of possibility of Black fungibility under slavery and its afterlife.

The question of time and space is of particular importance here. Intersectionality's infinite exchangeability (fungibility), which hinges partly on the severing of its genealogical ties with Black feminists (natal alienation), fits neatly with the framing of Black bodies and Black cultural or scholarly production as unfettered by time and space. Wilderson (2010, 235) argues: "[b]oth jazz and hip-hop have become known in the same way that Black bodies are known: as forces 'liberated' from time and space, belonging nowhere and to no one, simply there for the taking". For Sexton (2016), the state of permanent *placelessness* for Black people is the logical extension of the structural and ontological anti-Blackness embedded in the modernity's construction of "the human" through Black people's eviction from that category – a central Afropessimist tenet. Here Patterson's argument linking the slave's expulsion from humanity to natal alienation and social death is instructive. For Patterson, the "incapacity to make any claims of birth or to pass on such claims is considered a natural injustice among all peoples, so that those who were obliged to suffer it had to be regarded as somehow socially dead" (1982, 8). Thus, denying the slaves' independent social existence, denying them a past and a future is denying the slave's humanity. Following Hartman's theorizing of slavery's afterlife, it stands to reason that fungibility and natal alienation still apply to Black bodies and bodies of knowledge, as what follows the emancipation is a restructured plantation system rather than "self-possession, citizenship, or liberty of the 'freed'" (Hartman 1997, 12). If slavery exceeds its historical site, so does the fungible object status of the 'freed' Blacks and their natal alienation. The resulting (a)temporality taps into the idea of permanent timelessness and placelessness that forms part of intersectionality's fungibility in today's academe, which also echoes with duCille's (1994) earlier critique of how the university engages Black feminist theory without its history and intellectual ancestry – argument reminiscent of natal alienation.

Addressing specifically temporal attachments at work in intersectionality's institutional life under WGS' purview, Nash (2014, 46) identifies two temporalities: one future-oriented (*feminism-future*) and the other past-oriented (*feminism-past*). Despite their diametrically contrasting claims[12], both share the same racial substructure that entails shedding Black women. In both cases, it is Black women's centrality in intersectionality that is viewed as problem. Nash judiciously pinpoints how Black women are ejected from the present, when

> intersectionality's imagined peril hinges on its attachment to black women's bodies, and its promise comes from its willingness to transcend [their] (imagined) social location. […]black women's bodies are not the subjects of the present moment; they are, in fact, constructed as *out of time*.[…] [T]he ongoing preoccupation of women's studies with intersectionality[…] performs a certain kind of violence on black women's bodies and on black feminism: presuming that black women's bodies are *always already anachronisms*. (60–61, my emphasis)

Nash's perceptive analysis of the temporal work at play in WGS' dealings with intersectionality doesn't deploy Afropessimist concepts; using additional insights from concepts like fungibility and natal alienation enables an analysis of not only temporality at work but also spatiality. When reconsidered from the angle of natal alienation and deracination, redefining intersectionality as "a productive rhizomatic deterritorialization", as Nina Lykke (2011, 208) proposed, gains a dramatically different meaning. It is no longer the fashionable postmodern mobility but forced alienation of one's natal rights and uprooting, echoing the master's power to remove slaves from the local community in which they were brought up which lurks as a permanent threat of "deracination" (Patterson 1982, 6).

Against celebratory views of intersectionality's marvellous mobility across the globe, I make here a polemical argument: Just as the Middle Passage turned the Black subject into fungible object, the transatlantic travel of intersectionality in the opposite direction can be thought as transforming the embodied Black feminist intersectionality into a disembodied universal shell. Ergo, the use of the Saïdian metaphor of "travelling theory" requires critical attention as it frequently serves to justify Black women's removal from intersectionality. The challenge is not to oppose intersectionality's travels but to develop a power-accountable approach raising difficult questions of who benefit from them. Through Bourdieu's arguments about the university field, one can address the "travelling theory" as a locus of struggle to determine what features of intersectionality are relevant for the new context, who gets to decide what is relevant, for whom. It comes as no surprise that those who decide have bigger social and cultural capital and act as the importers, brokers, curators, translators or gatekeepers of intersectionality in the "new" context (Bilge 2013). Consider for instance how the pervasive denial of race as a relevant analytical and political category in European intersectionality scholarship marginalizes intersectional Black and WoC feminist work in Europe (Lewis 2013). Conferences and publications on European intersectionality regularly include famous Black feminists from US or *à la rigueur* from UK, while excluding Black feminists from continental Europe. Aligned with hegemonic denials of race's significance in Europe, some scholars aspire to foster a "European-inflected intersectionality" unfettered by "race-bound" frameworks developed by US-scholars of colour (Tomlinson 2013, 256–7), hence deemed

more suitable for "universal consumption" (Crenshaw 2011, 224). Pinpointing postraciality as intersectionality's unexpected travel partner, Crenshaw views this postracial intersectionality as "a product of those who rather enjoy the intersectional frame without the Black female bodies that were initially attached to it", and incisively captures the chain of significations at play: how postraciality becomes "further delineated as post-blackness, Black fatigue and post-Black womanness" (2014).

I contend that if intersectionality moves *with* Black women as embodied theory-and-praxis, it would be more relevant, not less, (both analytically and politically) to multiply-oppressed groups in the "new" context and in a better position to amplify (not colonize) past and present marginalized knowledges produced by these groups – knowledges centreing multiply-marginalized, hence kin to intersectionality. Therein lies intersectionality's robust potential for contributing to a global conversation among the multiply-oppressed. In arguing this, I part company with scholars like Nash, who recently urged intersectionality to become "expansive, broad, and deterritorialized enough to move with figures beyond 'black woman'" (2019, 104). While I recognize her statement's nuance, for moving with figures beyond Black women doesn't equate to moving past Black women, I feel uneasy with its implications. In foregrounding the necessity for intersectionality to "surrender its exclusive investment in black woman and emphasize the analytic's capacity to speak to 'women of color' broadly" (104), Nash gives the impression that there is a strong opposition among intersectional Black feminists against the analytic's use for groups other than Black women. I must stress that in my seventeen years of academic engagement with intersectionality as a non-Black woman of colour, which include major collaborations with Black feminist scholars of intersectionality, I haven't found this to be the case. Rather, I have seen all too often a refusal to hear Black feminists' qualms about the assumption that intersectionality's global reach necessarily requires its *moving past* (rather than *moving with*) Black women. What I have found is that their objections are often taken lightly, met with dismissive and shallow responses. Consider one such instance which also implicates me.

On December 15th 2017, I was invited to give a lecture titled *The trouble with post-Black feminist intersectionality* at the University of Amsterdam's Research Centre for Gender and Sexuality (ARC-GS). As a French and English speaking, light-skinned non-Black woman of colour, a tenured professor in a North American university, I have easier access into many academic spaces. But not on every occasion I am mindful of learning about local power inequalities and how to use my access in ways that disrupt institutional exclusions. On this occasion, I accepted the invitation without properly ensuring that an event designed to take issue with Black women's exclusion from intersectionality includes European, particularly Dutch, Black feminists. Although I voiced to organizers my wish to meet local racialized

intersectionality scholars and activists, I didn't make their involvement in the event a condition for my participation, as I should have done. Moreover, I lumped together Black women and WoC under the general term of "racialized", falling thereby into the trap of "women-of-color-blindness" – adapting from Sexton's (2010) critique of "people-of-color-blindness". My oversight was all the more disconcerting given my use of Afropessimism to address the problem of intersectionality's post-Black feminist turn. The incongruity of the situation was not lost on Black activists who came to voice their disagreement, and justifiably so, with an event addressing in its content Black feminist erasure while reenacting it in its very staging. They were rightfully upset at me. Faced with their intervention, I stepped back, leaving the stage to discussions about the university's structural anti-Blackness of which my ill-conceived lecture was part and parcel. Before sitting down, I called the situation a "cruel irony" materializing Barbara Christian's exact words (opening this article) that my aborted lecture was supposed to begin with.

During the heated debates that took place in lieu of my lecture, one could see a divided audience. One fault-line concerned whether as a non-Black WoC, I should be able to talk about Black feminism without Black women's involvement. To that, my own (belated) answer is negative. I should have known better and either shared the platform or not come at all. Another fault-line was about who is Black and the idea of "political blackness" as a coalitional political identity encompassing all people of colour. Although I have found on-the-spot discussions overall constructive, I couldn't help but notice some worrisome drifts. Instead of focusing on the violence enacted by this ill-conceived (mostly by my own neglect) event, some interventions sought to depict me as a WoC victim of Black women's so-called divisive identity politics. To that, my answer has been (as when I took social media to partake in post-event debates): not in my name – all the while reckoning that what happened precedes and exceeds me. As a group of Black feminists who published a chapter on this event under the name of Cruel Ironies Collective (CIC) incisively put it:

> Following the ARC-GS's public acknowledgment of the event's shortcomings, we've seen the continuation of extensive conversations and the release of think-pieces from non-Black womxn and men of color condemning our intervention as divisive identity politics or contesting the importance of a distinct Black womxn positionality. Misrepresentations proliferate in these pieces, which channel tropes of angry Black womanhood, the intellectual poverty of Black activists and the construction of Black self-representation as aggression and division. We've seen the strawman victimization of Sirma Bilge and the erasure of her gesture of solidarity to distort this narrative into one in which Black womxn activists are tyrants. For us, our intervention has only ever been about the inclusion of Black womxn in institutions that appropriate Black womxn's thought; an idea that, when coming from Bilge, warranted an academic platform, but when it is articulated by Black womxn in Amsterdam, seems to be unacceptable. And

> finally, we've seen the premise of our original intervention eclipsed by an identity crisis in Dutch anti-racism that conveniently makes impossible the articulation of our concerns: the problem of political Blackness. Cruelly, ironically, we've found our efforts to represent Blackness as Black people twisted into an alibi for rampant anti-blackness by non-Black people of colour. (2019, 184–185)

The ensuing accusations levelled at Black activists who staged the intervention of being non-coalitional or essentialist were worrisome, for they deflected from valid criticism and weaponized the idea of political blackness, using it against Black activists. Instead of viewing this intervention as a collective occasion "to hear this critique articulated by Black womxn who were familiar with anti-Blackness and misogynoir at Dutch universities" (186), their accusations framed it as undermining much-needed coalitional work to dismantle white supremacy. I believe in the importance of coalitional work, but no viable solidarity politics can be built in my view if we persist in not hearing Black feminists' concerns and fall into "WoC-blindness". Non-Black-WoC need to address our participation in this elusion.

Another example of misrepresentation of Black feminist concerns around intersectionality is found in an article tellingly titled "Intersectionality's amazing journey" published in the first special issue dedicated to intersectionality in Italy.[13] In there, the author takes issue, by her own admission, "with proponents of 'intersectionality' which believe, that a theoretical concept cannot/should not be detached from its original context of invention" and argues, "the traveling of a theory in a global context automatically involves appropriations, amendments and changes in response to the original meaning" (Lutz 2016, 437). Conjuring up a fatalism giving the impression that there is nothing we can do, that change is unavoidable and automatic, this stance leads to dismiss Black feminist concerns over their erasure through travelling. While Lutz gestures towards those concerns, when claiming, "[t]his fear of witnessing the erasure of 'Black women' in the process of the transnational traveling and appropriation of intersectionality is a concern that needs to be addressed" (422), she rapidly discards them, concluding there is no major problem: "It is true that in a concept which is globally appropriated changes and twists will always result in a metamorphosis of the original. This can be experienced as painful, but in the case of intersectionality I cannot detect a misuse of such gravity that we should regret it" (430). Such hasty dismissals prove Vivian May's assessment right. Tackling the paradoxical double move which intersectionality is caught up with, May argues, intersectionality's "recognition can entail avoidance, even suppression, of Black women's knowledge, even as it may seem to signal engagement", and adds, "Black feminist theorists seem to continue to find themselves in many ways *"speaking into the void*" (Crenshaw 2011, 228), even as their works are widely celebrated" (May 2014, 94–5). In the face of enduring inaudibility of Black feminists' concerns, encapsulated in Crenshaw's "speaking into the void" formulation, one can

hardly disagree with Wilderson's pessimism: "The object status of Blackness means that it can be placed and displaced with limitless frequency and across untold territories, by whoever so chooses. Most important, there is nothing real Black people can do to either check or direct this process" (2010, 235).

Whilst it is hard to disagree with Wilderson's pessimist conclusion, it is equally hard to sit with it. Despite all, many Black feminists continue to challenge their erasure from intersectionality. Here, I believe it is vital that non-Black feminists engaging intersectionality assume "the position of a front or defensive line" (King 2019) against academic extractivism and epistemic violence exercised by Black women's removal from intersectionality. This is all the more important as intersectionality is viewed by many practitioners as the backbone of solidarity politics. In an alternative reading of Nash's critique of Black feminist defensiveness over intersectionality, King makes a promising suggestion:

> Rather than castigate white women as perpetual perpetrators of aggression, might it be possible to invite them to take up defensiveness or become a defensive line against anti-black violence? Defensiveness as a mode of hypersensitivity or attunement to racist aggression could create a space of shared sensation or affect that all bodies (even white women's) bodies can take up or merge with to create an organism oriented toward protecting Black life. (2019)

Agreeing with her, I would suggest adding non-Black WoC to those invited to constitute a defensive line. My main motivation in writing this article has been to contribute to a deeper understanding of anti-Black-women violence reenacted in contemporary academic dealings with intersectionality.

Concluding remarks

This article traced how intersectionality as grounded in Black women's experience and knowledge is made fungible in present-day academe, treated as an empty receptacle "vulnerable to the projection of others' feelings, ideas, desires, and values" (Hartman 1997, 21), turned into a proxy for master narratives that erase Black women. Through the interpretive lens of Afropessimism, it linked intersectionality's "post-Black-womanness" (Crenshaw 2014) to the structural position of fungibility, i.e. infinitely accumulable and exchangeable commodity-status of Black bodies, experiences and knowledges in slavery's afterlife.

The claims made here don't imply that intersectional research should only be done by Black scholars, nor should it exclusively focus on Black women. The point is that our engagements with intersectionality must avoid rendering Black women and Black feminist knowledge an empty vessel openly vulnerable to the whims of the (academic) world and the projections of others, a fungible object through which other agendas are shored up. Afropessimist

insights, such as fungibility, slavery's afterlife and natal alienation, can be used to develop collectively other reading, citing, research, teaching and travelling practices, and most importantly to join forces to become a defensive line against the violent extraction of Black feminist intellectual labour and the deeply entrenched structures of anti-Blackness and anti-Black-womanness in the academy and society at large. As long as these structures remain intact, Black knowledge and cultural production are unlikely to avoid the peril of fungibility, and Black feminist scholars are likely to find themselves speaking, time and again, into the void.

Notes

1. Financial bubble simile occurred to me while reading King's (2015) discerning account of anxious graduate student behaviour regarding intersectionality, which also resonated with my experiences. Anxiety over bad investment (in an allegedly passé concept like intersectionality) is palpable, as is finding the next big thing to invest in. These feelings are consistent with self-investing new academic subjects and contradictory interpellations of neoliberal academe.
2. Two recent books tackle, albeit very differently, this relationship: Tomlinson (2018) and Nash (2019).
3. Valued as tokens, these bodies of knowledge are met with contempt within the academy: "doubly devalued, or minoritized, […]associated with scholars who face a general intellectual discrimination […], and attacked as inquiry that fails to achieve the ideal of academic disinterestedness" (Alcoff and Mohanty 2006, 7–8). They are hence akin to Foucault's "subjugated knowledge" –a whole series of knowledges "disqualified as non-conceptual knowledges, as insufficiently elaborated knowledges, […] knowledges that are below the required level of erudition and scientificity" ([1976]2003, 7).
4. Despite some kinship claims between them – e.g. Dixon labelled Afropessimism the "nappy headed stepchild of intersectionality" (2018a), then retracted to call it a "play cousin" (2018b) – neither the substance of Black women's scholarly work viewed as foundational to Afropessimist thought, nor the central premises of intersectionality and of Afropessimism support the claim of genealogical links. Contrariwise, several analysts view incompatibilities between them. For Warren, intersectional analyses "attempt to either reconcile blackness with humanity and its difference or conceive of blackness as ontologically equivalent with features of human difference" (2017, 394), and are hence inadequate for addressing the specificity of anti-Black violence. For Douglass (2018), intersectionality's insistence on gender does not take into account a central tenet of Afropessimist Black feminism, that Black people have been ungendered through slavery (Spillers 1987).
5. For Thomas, some US Black academics adopted the term Afropessimism "without any apparent sense of the history of its ravaging the African continent and without any reference whatsoever to the history of insistent Black political-intellectual resistance to its application to Africans on the continent and in the diaspora" (2018, 285). He distinguishes this second iteration as "Afropessimism *2.0*". For Woods, "one of the major limitations" of Afropessimism is the fact that "the tradition it calls forth clashes with the tradition in which it is rightfully situated", which he exposes thusly:

> Long before Hartman, the term "afro-pessimism" was originally coined to refer to a body of scholarship, journalism, commentary, and policy prognostications about the continent of Africa post-independence. The main feature of this original "afro-pessimism" is the notion that Africa's destiny lies in war, violence, disease, corruption, and hopelessness due to the incapacity of Africans to make improvements in the state of health, poverty, development, peace, and governance since the end of the colonial period. The original "afro-pessimism," then, is merely the post-colonial extension of the nineteenth-century racist tracts on civilization and history created to justify Western empire. (2018)

Both authors view the work of Cheikh Anta Diop (1991) as foundational to the articulation of African-optimism and a radical critique of the original Afropessimism, which gained currency in international relations theory from the 1980s on. Afropessimism hence originally refers to a highly problematic way of viewing "sub-Saharan" Africa as a region beyond hope for democracy and economic development, a doomed continent extending the colonial "dark continent" thesis (Momoh 2003). Some proponents of original Afropessimism went so far as to call for abandoning Africa or its recolonizing. Such a recycled use of a controversial term without acknowledgment of its longer history and charged (neo)-colonial legacies in Africa is telling of US academe's obliviousness to knowledge produced elsewhere. The irony here is only bigger, for academics involved are US Black scholars, and elsewhere is Africa.

6. See e.g., *Theory & Event* (21:1, 2018), *Afro-Pessimism and Black Feminism* special issue, gathering ten original articles and a robust introduction penned by coeditors. Succinctly put, Afropessimism is often criticized for its limited engagement with Black feminisms, its negative (nihilistic) effects on Black feminist political agency, and its exclusive interest in only a certain strand of Black feminism articulated in the work of Spillers, Hartman and Wynter. King (2018) uses the term "*proto*-Afropessimist" to refer to the work of Spillers and Hartman which preceded the advent of the US-brand of Afropessimism in the 2000s and greatly influenced the work of self-identified Afropessimist scholars like Wilderson and Sexton. Yet, neither Spillers nor Hartman self-identify as Afropessimist. Also, Wynter distanced her work from (Black) feminism (Malaklou and Willoughby-Herard 2018, 55, citing Wynter's 2006 interview with Greg Thomas.). An engagement with Afropessimism with a critical eye on its elisions on Black women and Black gender(s) is found in the work of Black feminists such as Patrice Douglass, Erica Edwards, Tiffany King, Shoniqua Roach, and Terrion Willamson.
7. I am aware that such stance has been criticized as a proprietary relation marked by (negative) defensiveness, and people holding it invited to embrace a more positive feeling of "letting go" (see Nash 2019). For Nash, "the proprietary impulses of black feminism" engender a "defensive affect" which "traps black feminism, hindering its visionary world-making capacities" (3). Seeking to disrupt a set of black feminist practices she identifies as "holding on", her project intends to foster "letting go" – a "political and theoretical worldview […], a vision of black feminist theory that is not invested in making property of knowledge" (3). Here, I propose another reading of Black feminist resistance against Black women's removal from intersectionality – one that reinterprets it from the angle of fungibility and slavery's afterlife (Hartman 1997, 2007), and

natal alienation (Patterson 1982), hence as a refusal of being turned into accumulable empty vessel and a claim to one's humanity, worlds of meaning, genealogy and filial rights.

8. In a *Handbook on Gender and Violence*, the entry on intersectionality provides the following definition: "The concept of intersectionality refers to the intersection of gender with inequalities of race, ethnicity, class, sexuality, age and other systems of domination" (Rolandsen-Agustin and Lombardo 2019, 43). A graduate and advanced undergraduate course offered in 2018 in a leading Canadian university presents intersectionality thusly: "This course introduces students to the theory, practice, and contradictions of intersectionality. First coined by legal scholar Kimberlé Crenshaw, 'intersectionality' names an approach that recognizes the centrality of gender and diversity to nearly all research problems" (in file with author). This presentation reframes intersectionality as a gender-centred approach, evacuates unequal power relations through depoliticized diversity, and subtly mutes race by qualifying Crenshaw a legal scholar, omitting her key intellectual lineage: critical race theory. This university also invests in intersectionality as one of its "signature" research areas – areas pursuing the goal of making the institution a globally recognized leader – but remodels it as "intersections of gender". I was told by a senior administrator that the initial idea proposed by (white) WGS scholars was a signature area in gender and sexualities, and intersectionality was added later to bring it *au goût du jour*.
9. Held at the Goethe University in Frankfurt on 22–23 January 2009, the conference *Celebrating Intersectionality? Debates on a Multi-Faceted Concept in Gender Studies* marked the 20th anniversary of the concept's advent by Crenshaw in her landmark 1989 article and launched Goethe University's new WGS department. Crenshaw contributed to the follow-up publication with a "Postscript" (2011) and the reprint of her 1989 article.
10. For Douglass, Terrefe and Wilderson, Patterson' work transformed the "sacrosanct tenets in slave studies to recompose the slave as an object, not a laborer" through his conceptualization of the slave as socially dead, premised on three constituents: natal alienation, gratuitous violence, and general dishonour. While he proposed "social death as a generalizable (and nonracial) condition, infecting every slave's status since antiquity, Afropessimists have "distilled and completed his gesture, recognizing social death as a paradigm whose singular relation to blackness furnishes all of human relationality." (2018, 3).
11. See King (2019) and Williamson (2019), for alternative, more generative, readings of Black feminist "defensiveness".
12. The future-oriented project works in a "movement of intersectionality toward the inevitable future" with "calls for more intersectionality, an attention to more intersections, and pleas for more disciplines adopting intersectionality", while the past-oriented one congeals intersectionality in a bygone era, "in an already-transcended past", authorizing the calls to move beyond it, "its hegemony, its problematic practice, its shortcomings, and its insistent use of identity-based knowledge and remedies", since according to this script "the valuable insights of intersectionality have already been incorporated into feminism" (Nash 2014, 46).
13. *Rassegna Italiana di Sociologia*, 2016, LVII(3), Enzo Colombo and Paola Rebughini (eds.).

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